5.2.2 Properties of magnetic lines of force

- Magnetic lines of force are closed, continuous curves, extending through the body of the magnet.
- Magnetic lines of force start from the North Pole and end at the South Pole.
- Magnetic lines of force never intersect.
- They will be maximum at the poles than at the equator.
- The tangent drawn at any point on the curved line gives the direction of magnetic field.

5.3 Magnetic effect of current

It was on 21st April 1820, Hans Christian Oersted, a Danish Physicist was giving a lecture. He was demonstrating electrical circuits in that class. He had to often switch on and off the circuit during the lecture. Accidentally, he noticed the needle of the magnetic compass that was on the table. It deflected whenever he switched on and the current was flowing through the wire. The compass needle moved only slightly, so that the audience didn't even notice. But, it was clear to Oersted that something significant was happening. He conducted many experiments to find out a startling effect, the magnetic effect of current.

Oersted aligned a wire XY such that they were exactly along the North-South direction. He kept one magnetic compass above the wire at A and another under the wire at B. When the circuit was open and no current was flowing through it, the needle of both the compass was pointing to north. Once the circuit was closed and electric current was flowing, the needle at A pointed to east and the needle at B to the west as shown in Figure 5.5. This showed that current carrying conductor produces magnetic field around it.

The direction of the magnetic lines around a current carrying conductor can be easily understood using the right hand thumb rule. Hold the wire with four fingers of your right hand with thumbs-up position. If the direction of the current is towards the thumb then the magnetic lines curl in the same direction as your other four fingers as shown in Figure 5.6. This shows that the magnetic field is always perpendicular to the direction of current.

The strength of the magnetic field at a point due to current carrying wire depends on: (i) the current in the wire, (ii) distance of the point from the wire, (iii) the orientation of the point from the wire and (iv) the magnetic nature of the medium. The magnetic field lines are stronger near the current carrying wire and it diminishes as you go away from it. This is represented by drawing magnetic field lines closer together near the wire and farther away from the wire.

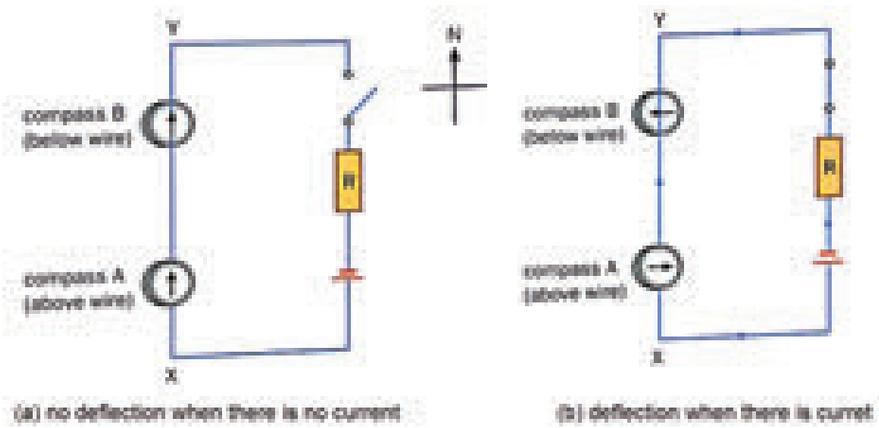


Figure 5.5 Current produces magnetic field

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